

SpectrumReady Digital Guide

Transition to Adulthood Planner

The Complete Year-by-Year Guide to Adult Services, SSI, Housing, Employment, and Financial Planning for Autism Families

\$47

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Important Notice — Please Read Before Proceeding

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Time-Sensitive Information. Government benefit amounts, income thresholds, and program eligibility rules change regularly. Dollar figures and thresholds in this guide reflect information as of 2025. Always verify current amounts and rules directly with the relevant federal or state agency before making any decisions.

Individual Circumstances Vary. Eligibility for the programs discussed depends on your individual circumstances. This guide describes how programs generally work — not whether you or your child specifically qualifies.

Consult Professionals. For decisions about your child's specific situation — including SSI applications, IEP disputes, insurance appeals, or estate planning — consult a qualified special education attorney, disability benefits counselor, or other licensed professional.

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Introduction: The Transition Cliff

Parents of children with autism often speak of a "transition cliff" — the moment when the intensive school-based services that supported their child for 18 years end, and the adult service system (underfunded, fragmented, and difficult to navigate) must pick up the pieces.

The statistics are sobering: only 58% of autistic young adults are employed in their first two years after high school. Nearly half live with parents as adults. Waitlists for adult residential and day services often stretch 5–15 years.

But families who plan early — starting at age 12 or even younger — arrive at that cliff with a bridge already built. This guide is your bridge-building manual.

THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT INSIGHT IN THIS GUIDE

Adult services have waiting lists measured in years and sometimes decades. The families who get services are the ones who got on the waiting list years before they needed them. Start today, regardless of your child's age.

Part 1: The Adult Services Ecosystem

How Adult Services Differ from Children's Services

Children's System	Adult System
Entitlement-based (IDEA, EPSDT)	Largely needs-based with waiting lists
School-led coordination	Self/family navigated
Many free services	Primarily insurance/Medicaid-funded
One primary contact (IEP team)	Multiple agencies, no coordinator
Services guaranteed by law	Services subject to funding and availability

The Major Adult Service Categories

1. Medicaid-Funded Adult Services

Medicaid remains the backbone of adult disability services. Two main types:

- **State Plan Services:** Outpatient therapy, mental health, medical care
- **HCBS Waivers:** The critical funding source for day programs, residential, employment supports, respite

2. Vocational Rehabilitation (VR)

Federally funded, state-administered program that funds job training, supported employment, assistive technology, and college support. Must apply — not automatic. Most states start VR services at age 16 while student is still in school.

3. Developmental Disabilities (DD) Agency

Your state's DD agency coordinates adult services including residential options, day programs, employment supports, and crisis services. This is the agency that manages HCBS waiver waiting lists.

4. Social Security (SSI/SSDI)

At age 18, parental income is no longer counted. Almost every autistic young adult should apply for SSI on or just before their 18th birthday. This is frequently the largest source of income and also triggers Medicaid continuation.

5. Supported Employment Programs

Customized Employment and Supported Employment programs match autistic adults with jobs suited to their strengths and provide job coaching. Funded through VR and HCBS waivers.

Part 2: Year-by-Year Planning Timeline

Ages 12–14: Laying the Foundation

- ☐ Start transition-focused IEP goals — IDEA requires transition planning to begin by age 16, but starting at 12–14 gives you more time
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- ☐ Get on your state's DD agency waiting list NOW if not already on it
- ☐ Apply for ABLE account if not already open
- ☐ Begin vocational exploration — what does your child enjoy? What are they good at?
- ☐ Start building self-advocacy skills
- ☐ Explore guardianship alternatives — decision support, supported decision-making

Ages 14–16: Building Toward Independence

- ☐ First formal transition IEP — include vocational goals, post-secondary vision
- ☐ Invite the student to participate meaningfully in their own IEP meeting
- ☐ Begin community-based vocational experiences
- ☐ Contact Vocational Rehabilitation — students can be enrolled while still in school
- ☐ Research post-secondary options: college, trade programs, day programs, supported employment
- ☐ Begin financial planning: SSI projections, Special Needs Trust planning

Ages 16–18: Active Transition Work

- ☐ Transition IEP must specify: post-secondary education goals, employment goals, independent living goals
- ☐ Increase work experience and community participation
- ☐ Active VR enrollment and service plan
- ☐ Consult an attorney about guardianship options (18th birthday planning)
- ☐ Begin SSI application at age 17 years and 9 months (can apply up to 3 months early)
- ☐ Tour adult day programs and residential options — even years ahead of need
- ☐ Meet with estate planning attorney about Special Needs Trust

Age 18: The Major Transition Points

- ☐ **SSI APPLICATION** — file as close to the 18th birthday as possible; parental income no longer counted

- ☐ Medicaid continuation (SSI triggers Medicaid in most states)

- ☐ Legal decisions: who can make healthcare and financial decisions? Guardianship? Supported decision-making?

- ☐ Selective Service registration (required for males within 30 days of 18th birthday)

- ☐ Healthcare transition — move from pediatric to adult providers

- ☐ College: disability services registration (very different process than K-12)

Ages 18–22: Final School Years (IDEA Extends to Age 21/22)

- ☐ Maximize school-based transition services — this is the last free intensive support

- ☐ Paid work experience with supports

- ☐ Independent living skills training

- ☐ Finalize post-secondary placement (job, program, college, or combination)

- ☐ Establish adult medical team before school ends

- ☐ Handoff from school-based services to adult VR and DD services

Age 22+: Adult Life Launch

- ☐ HCBS waiver services begin (if on waiting list since childhood)

- ☐ Employment: supported, competitive integrated, self-employment

- ☐ Housing: family home, shared living, supervised residential, own home

- ☐ Ongoing medical, behavioral, and mental health support

- ☐ Annual SSI review and update

Part 3: Guardianship vs. Alternatives

What Is Guardianship?

Legal guardianship gives you the court-authorized right to make legal, financial, and/or medical decisions for another adult who is determined to lack decision-making capacity. It is not automatic — you must petition the court.

GUARDIANSHIP IS NOT ALWAYS THE RIGHT ANSWER

Full guardianship removes all legal rights from your child. Many autistic adults can make their own decisions in some or most areas — they just need support and accessibility accommodations to do so. Removing all rights can undermine self-determination and dignity. Consider alternatives first.

Guardianship Types

Type	What It Covers	Best For
Full/Plenary Guardianship	All decisions — medical, financial, residential	Individuals who truly cannot make any decisions independently
Limited Guardianship	Specific areas only (e.g., medical only)	Individuals with partial decision-making capacity
Guardianship of the Person	Personal/medical decisions	When financial decisions are not in question
Guardianship of the Estate	Financial decisions only	When financial management is the concern

Alternatives to Guardianship

Alternative	Description	Cost
Supported Decision-Making Agreement	Formal agreement naming trusted people to support decision-making without removing rights	Low — template agreements available
Healthcare Proxy / Medical POA	Designates a decision-maker for medical situations only	Free to low cost
Durable Power of Attorney	Financial decision-making support	Attorney fees — \$200–\$500
Representative Payee	SSA program — manages SSI payments; does not require guardianship	Free

Part 4: Financial Planning for the Future

The Special Needs Trust (SNT)

A Special Needs Trust allows you to leave money to your child without disqualifying them from SSI and Medicaid. Without a properly structured SNT, an inheritance over \$2,000 disqualifies your child from SSI.

Types of Special Needs Trusts

Type	Funded By	Best For
First-Party / Self-Settled SNT	Child's own assets (personal injury settlement, inheritance directly to child)	When child receives direct inheritance or legal award
Third-Party SNT	Family members, estate planning	Most families — funded through will, life insurance, gifting
Pooled SNT	Non-profit manages pool of beneficiary funds	Smaller trusts where private trustee isn't practical

CRITICAL: USE AN ATTORNEY

A poorly drafted Special Needs Trust can disqualify your child from benefits. Use an attorney who specializes in special needs planning. Find one through the Academy of Special Needs Planners (specialneedsanswers.com).

ABLE Account (Supplement to SNT)

ABLE accounts (covered in the Benefits Navigator) complement Special Needs Trusts. Use for smaller, flexible expenses. SNT for larger, managed assets.

Life Insurance Considerations

Your child may depend on you financially long after most adults are independent. Consider:

- Sufficient life insurance to fund the SNT
- Name the Special Needs Trust as beneficiary — never name the child directly
- Term vs. permanent insurance: consult a fee-only financial planner

Letter of Intent

Not a legal document, but equally important: a Letter of Intent is a detailed guide for future caregivers describing your child's medical needs, communication style, preferences, behaviors, routines, relationships, and what matters most to them. Write this and update it annually.

Part 5: SSI at Age 18

This is the highest-impact financial action most autism families can take. When your child turns 18:

- Parental income is NO LONGER counted — even high-income families may now qualify
- Only the child's own income and assets are considered
- Benefit: up to \$943/month (2024, adjusted annually)
- SSI triggers Medicaid in most states — maintaining healthcare coverage

How to Apply at 18

1. Apply at SSA.gov or by calling 1-800-772-1213 — can apply up to 3 months before 18th birthday
2. Gather: proof of age, Social Security card, medical records documenting autism and functional limitations, proof of income/assets
3. Complete the Adult Disability Report — describe your child's WORST days, not average days
4. If denied: appeal immediately. Do not accept the initial denial without appealing.

Protecting SSI Eligibility

- Keep countable resources under \$2,000 (ABLE account and SNT assets are excluded)
- Report all income and resource changes to SSA within 10 days
- Understand what counts as income: wages, gifts, in-kind support
- Get a Representative Payee if your child cannot manage their SSI payments

Part 6: Post-Secondary Education

Types of Post-Secondary Programs

Program Type	Examples	Best For
Inclusive college programs	Think College network	Students who want college experience with supports
Certificate/vocational programs	Community college, trade school	Career-focused, specific skill development
Transition programs (18–22)	School-based, often campus-hosted	Students completing IDEA-funded transition services
Adult learning programs	Community-based, non-credit	Life skills, social, community participation

College Disability Services — Key Differences from K-12

- Colleges do NOT have to develop IEPs or provide FAPE
- Students must self-identify and self-advocate — the system will not find them

- Documentation of disability must be provided by the student
- Accommodations are reasonable modification, not specialized education
- Register with the disability services office before classes start

Part 7: Employment Pathways

Employment Models

Model	Description	Who It's Best For
Competitive Integrated Employment	Regular job at minimum wage or higher, working alongside non-disabled peers	All autistic adults should be given the opportunity
Supported Employment	Competitive employment with ongoing job coaching support	Those who need support to maintain employment
Customized Employment	Job carved or created to match individual's specific strengths	Individuals with complex needs
Self-Employment / Microenterprise	Own business, often using special interest as foundation	Individuals with strong specific interests and entrepreneurial potential

The Role of Vocational Rehabilitation

VR provides: career assessment, job training, supported employment funding, workplace accommodations, college funding, and more. Free for eligible individuals with disabilities. Apply as early as age 16 in most states.

Autism-Friendly Employers

Many major employers have active neurodiversity hiring programs including Microsoft, SAP, JPMorgan Chase, EY, and others. These programs provide structured onboarding and ongoing support for autistic employees.

Part 8: Housing Options for Adults with Autism

The Housing Spectrum

Setting	Level of Support	Funding Sources
Family home	Family-provided support	SSI, VR, day programs
Shared living / Host home	Adult lives with and is supported by a trained family	HCBS waiver
Supported living / ILS	Own home or apartment with scheduled support staff	HCBS waiver, SSI, Section 8
Group home / CLA	Shared home with 24-hour residential staff	HCBS waiver
ICF/IDD	Institutional setting with intensive medical support	Medicaid

THE GOAL: SUPPORTED INDEPENDENCE

Research consistently shows that autistic adults do best with the least restrictive setting that still meets their needs. Supported independent living — own or shared home with paid support staff — is the preferred model for most autistic adults and is significantly less expensive than institutional settings.

Section 8 / Housing Choice Voucher for Adults

Disabled adults can receive Section 8 vouchers — subsidizing rent in private housing. Waiting lists are long. If your child is on a Section 8 waiting list from childhood, confirm they can transfer to an adult voucher. Apply at your local PHA today if not already on the list.

Master Transition Checklist by Age

Age 12–14

- ☐ Get on state DD agency waiting list
- ☐ Open ABLE account
- ☐ Begin vocational exploration
- ☐ Start self-advocacy skill building
- ☐ Research guardianship alternatives

Age 14–16

- ☐ Transition IEP begins
- ☐ Contact Vocational Rehabilitation
- ☐ Community work experiences begin
- ☐ Research post-secondary options
- ☐ Begin Special Needs Trust planning

Age 16–18

- ☐ Apply for SSI at 17 years 9 months
- ☐ Meet with estate planning attorney
- ☐ Tour adult day programs and residential options
- ☐ Active VR enrollment
- ☐ Make guardianship decisions

Age 18

- ☐ SSI application submitted
- ☐ Selective Service registration (males)
- ☐ Legal decision-making structure in place
- ☐ Healthcare transition to adult providers
- ☐ College disability services registration if applicable

Ages 18–22

- ☐ Maximize school-based transition services
- ☐ Paid work experience with supports
- ☐ Independent living skills training
- ☐ Adult medical team established
- ☐ Post-secondary placement finalized

Key Resources

Resource	Where
Think College (post-secondary programs)	thinkcollege.net
Autism Speaks Adult Services	autismspeaks.org/adult-services
Academy of Special Needs Planners	specialneedsanswers.com
ABLE National Resource Center	ablenrc.org
US Dept of Labor — Disability Resources	dol.gov/agencies/odep

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Empowering autism families with the knowledge they deserve.

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This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal, financial, or medical advice. Program rules and benefit amounts are subject to change — verify current information with the relevant agency. For complex situations, consult a qualified professional.

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